ents—water, proteins, fats, carbohydrates, minerals and vitamins. Cats, in particular, require wet fresh food to take care of their hydration needs as they tend to drink less water as they grow older.

Vegetarian owners often unwittingly deprive their pets of high-quality protein that the animal needs in order to remain healthy. The general rule, says Kuchroo, is about 2-3 grams of protein for every kilo of body weight. "Protein not only builds muscle but also contains many essential amino acids for the animal. Nutritional deficiency reflects in the quality of fur, the animal's mood, longevity and overall health," she says. The more aware pet parents are now giving their animals nutritional supplements such as hemp seed oil as well as calcium, prebiotic and probiotic treats. Kuchroo herself has seen things change in the past decade that she has been in business. "We used to sell dog pizzas and cupcakes, and also had fresh food dabba service," she says. "Over the years, we have decided to focus on the latter segment." Her brand Doggie Dabbas offers six types of meal packs for dogs and Meow Chow has three kinds of food packs for cats. A monthly purchase for a medium-sized dog with no special medical requirements can cost Rs 8,000 to 10,000.

Along with the food, pets are also getting their own hangout spaces where they and their humans can spend quality time. And no, we are not talking about pet-friendly spaces, but ones specifically designated for pets. At A Dog's Story, a chain of boutique dog resorts, dogs are welcomed with marigold garlands, as human guests would in such spaces. "We have built our properties

BEING ZIGGY BASU

WHO: TWO-YEAR-OLD SHIH TZU DOG

PARENTS: KUNAL AND NEHA BASU

CLAIM TO FAME: TRAVEL AND FASHION INFLUENCER ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Whoever scoffed at "a dog's life" must visit Miss Ziggy the Piggy's Instagram profile. Describing herself as a travel and fashion influencer, she has a following of 17,500 on her page. Luxury fashion brands ply her with leather jackets, glittery lehengas, dungarees and bikinis. Her parent, Kunal, now thinks she has a bigger wardrobe than him. 2022 was a busy year, as Ziggy went travelling around the country—on a plane, in a kayak and sometimes trekking.

But Ziggy is no ordinary influencer—she's Neha and Kunal Basu's two-year-old Shih Tzu dog. Her parents say the only person they would swap their lives with is her. "It is as if a celebrity is walking in when she enters the local pet shop or spa," says Neha, who takes her to Petgascar once a week for a haircut and spa treatment. She has been doggedly documenting Ziggy's life with her camera.

> "IT IS AS IF A CELEBRITY IS WALKING IN WHEN SHE ENTERS THE LOCAL PET SHOP OR SPA"
> —NEHA BASU

On Ziggy's second birthday last year, the Basus took her to Juhu and did an Instalive session of her playing on the beach. Off to the spa it was after that, from where Ziggy emerged fluffy and dry to meet her friends and admirers

SPOILT FOR CHOICE
Petcare products at an HUFT store in Noida



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH